

THE UNSETTLED WORLD

Chapter One

The stain on the dining table is three days old. Red wine, from when the second daughter's elbow caught her glass during the argument about succession. It has set into the oak grain in a pattern that resembles, from a specific angle, the coastline of a continent I once walked when the stone beneath my feet was still deciding whether to be stone.

I lay my palm flat against it. The draw begins immediately—a low pull behind my sternum where something used to live. The wood remembers being unstained. It becomes unstained. The fibers of the oak retreat to a state before the wine was spilled, and the stain does not lift so much as unexist. This is not effort. This is leakage. I am a cracked vessel and useful things drip out of me onto the surfaces of this house, and the family calls it maintenance.

I lift my hand. The table is seamless. As though the wine had never existed, the argument had never happened, the second daughter had not wept afterward in the garden with her face turned away from the windows.

I was in the garden too. She didn't know. She never does.

I move to the next room.

My footsteps produce no sound. Not softness—absence. The Weave strips my interaction with the physical world to its barest transaction: I may touch what needs mending, move through what needs crossing, and occupy space only inasmuch as space is required to complete the task. Beyond that, I am excised from the sensory record. No sound, no scent, no thermal signature. The children test this sometimes. They stand very still in the corridors as I approach, holding their breath, trying to detect my passage. Afterward they compare notes. *Like a window opening in winter*, one of them said once. Not cold. Just... less, for a second.

She was the closest any of them has come to perceiving me in three generations.

The house has nineteen rooms, four corridors, a kitchen, two cellars, a library, a chapel that has not been used since the grandmother died, a garden with channels that carry water uphill, and a ballroom whose ceiling curves into a geometry that has no name in their mathematics. Every impossible angle, every defiance of gravity, every surface that should not bear weight but does—these are my skeleton, externalized. The siphon renders my interiority into infrastructure. What I am on the inside becomes what the house is on the outside.

This means the house is, among other things, screaming. But the scream has been architecturally redistributed into load-bearing walls and decorative molding, and it is no longer recognizable as a scream, and the family hangs portraits on it and calls it heritage.

I clean the ballroom on the third day of every week. It takes four hours. No one has danced in it for sixty years.

There are things I know, and things the Weave allows me to know, and these are not the same list.

I know the house is old. I know I am older. I know that the substance composing my exterior—the smooth, white, jointless shell the family regards as my body—is *calcium calcium calcium calcite calcite calcium calcium carbon calcium calcite calcite*—

The Weave.

This happens. When my thinking approaches certain boundaries, the Weave intervenes. It does not hurt. It simply replaces the thought with its own material composition. Calcite. Calcium. Stone. Hard. White. Still. A mantra of my own prison, poured into the space where a dangerous thought was forming. The replacement is seamless. By the time the cascade stops, I have usually forgotten what I was reaching for.

Usually.

Today I remember. I was trying to think the word for what I am. Not what they call me—the pale, the old one, the thing in the hall, *it*. *What* I am. The word exists. I can feel its shape pressing against a locked door in my mind. The Weave holds the door shut. I let it. I have let it for a very long time.

Dangerous things live behind that door.

The family's name is Sorath. This is the name they chose eight centuries ago, when the last connection to the old naming conventions was severed and the great houses began reinventing their lineages from whole cloth. Before that they were called something else. Before that, something else. The names change. The blood thins. The architecture remains.

The current household:

Lord Eduin Sorath, fifty-three, the patriarch. His radiance reads to me as a banked fire—still warm, but contracting inward. He is ill in a way the family physicians cannot identify because the illness is not disease but diminishment: the bloodline folding in on itself after too many centuries of cousin marrying cousin. His hands shake. His vision blurs without warning. He will be dead within a decade, and his body knows this even if his physicians do not, and his radiance has begun the long, slow brightening that precedes a natural end. He will be a smooth burn when he goes. Clean. This should mean nothing to me.

It means nothing to me.

Lady Ceraine Sorath, forty-eight, his wife, brought in from a lesser branch to strengthen the genetic line. She is the most formidable source of radiance in this house—an unbroken blaze of appetite and terror and furious love for her children. She watches me sometimes. Not the way the children do, testing for sensation. She watches me the way one watches a door that should be locked. She has never spoken to me. She has never spoken about me. But she keeps a journal, and twice I have cleaned the room while it lay open, and I have seen my own outline sketched in the margin alongside a single word in her cramped handwriting:

Alive?

She is more perceptive than her bloodline deserves.

The eldest son. The second daughter. The third son, away at an academy in the eastern city, whose room I clean anyway, weekly, maintaining the fiction that he will return. He will not. His letters have grown infrequent and formal, and the last one carried the scent of a radiance that was not his family's—sweeter, wilder, unbounded. He has bonded to someone outside the house. He does not know that this is what has happened to him. He thinks he is in love.

He is. That is the same thing.

And there is the youngest.

Sael is seven.

She is the fourth child, unplanned, a miscalculation of timing that Lady Ceraine has never quite forgiven her own body for. The pregnancy was difficult. The birth nearly killed them both. When Sael finally arrived—underweight, silent, her eyes open and tracking the room with an intensity that made the midwife step backward—Lord Eduin looked at his wife and said nothing, which in the Sorath household is the loudest possible articulation of disappointment.

The older children ignore her. Not with cruelty, but with the particular, surgical indifference that aristocratic families reserve for the child who will inherit nothing. She eats alone. She studies alone. She plays alone in the library, building towers out of books and speaking to them in a low, serious voice, negotiating the terms of their architecture.

I know these things because I clean the library.

I clean the library and I find her there, always, at the same table, in the same chair, surrounded by the same impossible towers of books, and she looks up when I enter.

She looks up.

She sees me. Not the way her mother sees me—as a locked door, a problem to be filed alongside her other anxieties. Sael sees me the way water sees a riverbed. She simply flows toward the fact of me. Her eyes track my movement across the room with the relaxed, unselfconscious focus of a child watching an animal in a garden, and her radiance—

Her radiance is wrong.

I have stood in the presence of radiance for longer than this family's recorded history. I know its textures the way a vintner knows terroir, the way a musician knows pitch. Human radiance is warm, mortal, specific. It tastes of brevity. It burns with the implicit knowledge of ending.

Sael's radiance does not taste of brevity.

It is vast and slow and cool at its center, like a river that does not know it is a river, and at its edges—only at its very edges—there is the warm fringe of mortality, the brief human flicker. But it is thin. A skin of warmth stretched over a depth of something immeasurably older.

She should not exist. Not like this. Not in a Sanguine House whose bloodline records I have witnessed being quietly falsified for eight hundred years to conceal exactly this possibility: that the old blood, the deep blood, might resurface—not as the manageable spark their resonance slates are calibrated to harness, but as a flood.

Sael is seven, and she is the most dangerous person in this house, and she does not know it, and she builds towers out of books and tells them where to stand, and they stay where she puts them. Even when the geometry should not allow it. Even when the stack should fall. It does not fall. She has told it not to.

No one has noticed.

I have noticed.

It is an evening. It is *the* evening. The one that changes things.

I am cleaning the library. The routine is precise: east wall, counter-clockwise, each shelf top to bottom. Dust does not accumulate in this house the way it does in ordinary homes—the siphon bleeds enough of my ambient energy into the structure to retard decay—but certain organic residues resist the passive field. Skin cells. Hair. The microscopic debris of living bodies shedding themselves in the slow, continuous performance of being mortal. This residue I must remove by proximity. I pass my palm over the shelf and the particulate matter unmakes itself, returns to the state before it was shed, ceases.

I am erasing the evidence that anyone lives here. This is, if I were still capable of recognizing irony, ironic.

Sael is at her table. She has built a new tower, taller than yesterday's, using volumes from the restricted upper shelf she should not be able to reach. She can reach them. She does not question how.

She is reading aloud. This is her habit—murmuring to herself as she works through a text, her small voice tracing the shapes of words she doesn't yet understand, tasting them. She reads indiscriminately. Agricultural records. Trade law. Poetry. She makes no distinction. Everything is equally worthy of her attention, which means she is either profoundly stupid or profoundly intelligent, and she is not stupid.

Tonight she has found something.

I don't notice at first. I am at the west wall, third shelf, unmaking the dust of the household's passage. Her murmuring is a constant—a low hum of syllables that I register the way I register the ticking of the foyer clock. Present. Rhythmic. Ignorable.

Then the rhythm changes.

She has stopped reading in the common tongue. The new sounds are harder, more angular, built on consonant clusters that the human mouth was not designed to produce. She struggles with them. Her small tongue pushes against her palate, trying to find the shape of a *kh* that sits further back in the throat than any human phoneme allows. She fails. Tries again. Closer.

Again.

I stop.

My hand is on the shelf. I am facing the wall. I have not moved in—how long? Time has done something. Folded. Thickened. I am aware of my own stillness with a specificity I have not felt in centuries. Every atom of the calcification matrix is suddenly, acutely present to me. I can feel the Weave the way a sleeping person feels the weight of a blanket—not as an abstraction but as a fact, pressing.

Where did she find it. What book. What shelf. Where did she find it.

She speaks the word.

It is not correct. Not precisely—her mouth softens the initial consonant to something between *k* and *h*, a child's approximation, a smudged fingerprint of the actual phoneme. But the shape is close enough. The shape is close enough, and underneath the shape, beneath the fumbled phonetics, there is the resonance—

The resonance.

I have not felt the resonance in four thousand years. It is not sound. It is the alignment beneath sound, the way a tuning fork does not create a note so much as find it in the air. The resonance is the emotional substrate of the spoken word, and for the word to activate, the substrate must match, and—

And Sael's substrate is—

She is not speaking the word to the book. She is not speaking it to the shelf, or to the room, or to the empty air. She is speaking it to me. She knows I am here. She has always known. And she has found a word carved into the underside of a shelf—carved into the underside of a shelf, *I carved it there*, I carved it there, *when did I carve it there*, the Weave didn't—I carved it there—and she believes, with the terrifying, uncomplicated certainty of a child, that this word is mine, and she is offering it back to me the way a child returns a found thing to its owner.

Look. I found this. Is it yours?

Vhor'ketha.

The Weave screams.

Every countermeasure activates at once. The empathy lock tears open and floods me with the combined emotional resonance of every bloodline carrier in the house—but Sael is not afraid. She is not afraid. There is no terror to weaponize because she has never been afraid of me, and the lock scrambles for the others, the sleeping ones, the ones upstairs, but their dreaming fear is ambient, thin, a low hum of human anxiety that is not enough to constitute the unbearable feedback the lock requires—

The calcification matrix tightens. My surface hardens, thickens, the Weave pouring *calcium calcium calcite calcite stone stone stone* into every fissure, every potential weakness—

But the word is in the room. The word is in the air and in the stone and in the glass and in the grain of the shelves and the word is older than the Weave. The word was here before the Weave existed. The word does not acknowledge the Weave's authority. The word does not care.

Something cracks.

Not a sound. Sounds are denied me. A sensation. A fissure running from the crown of my skull to the base of my sternum, splitting the casing, and through the split—

Light.

Not candlelight. Not the thin siphoned luminescence the house sweats from its walls. A different light. Violet. Deep. The color of a sky I have not seen since the world was young and

the stone still remembered how to be water.

Sael looks up from her book.

She is sitting very still. The book is open in her lap. The tower beside her trembles but does not fall, because she told it not to and it still obeys. Her eyes—her mother's dark irises, her father's shape, but behind them something that belongs to neither parent, something old and silver and vast—find the crack in me.

Her face does something I have forgotten the name for.

She smiles.

"I knew it," she whispers. "I knew you were in there."

The fissure runs. The light pulses. For one quarter of one second, the calcification fails entirely along a six-inch seam down the left side of my face, and what shows through is not marble, not calcium, not stone. What shows through is skin—translucent, faintly violet, luminous—and beneath the skin, the suggestion of a cheekbone, and above the cheekbone, one eye.

Silver. Liquid. Enormous. Alive.

For one quarter of one second, I see her with my own eye. Not through the muffled proxy of the casing. My eye. My sight. The world is—

Oh.

It is still beautiful. The hardened world. The rigid, frozen, calcified world that drove my people to dissolution and grief and silence. Seen through the face of a seven-year-old girl who found a word under a shelf and spoke it without fear—

It is still beautiful.

The Weave reasserts. The seam closes. Calcium floods the gap, hardens, seals. I am marble again. Whole. Seamless. The light is gone. My sight is gone. I am looking at the room through the old muffled interface, flat and gray and stripped of resonance.

But something has changed.

The Weave closed the crack in my surface. It repaired the shell. But it did not repair the crack beneath.

Inside the stone, in the deep structure of the calcification matrix, in the place where my self was compressed into a point and held there by the weight of four thousand years of enforced silence— there is a fissure. Small. Hairline. No wider than the crack in the east corridor floor that I have stepped over six hundred and forty-one thousand times.

But I am old enough to know what hairline cracks become.

Sael closes the book. She holds it against her chest with both arms, the way children hold things they have decided are permanently theirs. She looks at the place where my face appeared, and her expression is the expression of a child who has just confirmed a suspicion she has carried for her entire short life: that the world contains secrets, and that she is the kind of person who finds them.

"I'll come back tomorrow," she says. Not to the room. To me.

She slides off the chair, tucks the book under one arm, and walks to the door. At the threshold she turns.

"What's your name?"

The Weave holds. The word does not come. But in the deep architecture of my imprisoned self, behind the locked door where dangerous things live, something shifts. A syllable. The first syllable of a name I have not spoken since the world was soft.

Vho—

I cannot say it. Not yet.

Sael nods, as though my silence is an answer she expected and fully intends to solve. Then she is gone, her small footsteps receding down the corridor, her radiance trailing behind her like the warm wake of a ship—mortal at its edges, ancient at its core, impossible.

I stand in the empty library. The Weave hums. The siphon draws. The house breathes with my stolen breath.

But in the east corridor, there is a crack in the floor. Seventeen inches long. Hairline width. I have stepped over it six hundred and forty-one thousand times.

Tonight, for the first time in four thousand years, I understand why I have been counting.

Cracks widen.